

OWNLY ONCE

CREDIT READINESS KIT

VOLUME 02 OF SIX



WHAT'S HOLDING YOUR CREDIT SCORE BACK?

Find the factors you can address.
Choose your next move.



COMPLIMENTARY FIELD GUIDE

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FIELD GUIDE

Read the report behind the score

A score can tell you where you stand, but your credit reports help explain why. Start by reviewing your account history, reported balances, and unfamiliar information before choosing a strategy.

Your goal determines your next step

Preparing for housing, a vehicle, or a credit card may involve different requirements. Write down your goal and timing, then identify the report details and budget issues you can address.

My financial goal

My target date

The report or account I need to review first

There is no universal point increase or guaranteed timeline. This guide is general education; your file, scoring model, and lender requirements matter.

FIELD GUIDE

The five FICO score categories

FICO describes five broad categories with these general weights. Their influence varies by person, and other scoring models may work differently.

Category	General weight	What to examine
Payment history	35%	Late payments and how accounts have been paid.
Amounts owed	30%	Balances, available credit, and debt levels.
Length of credit history	15%	How long accounts have been established.
New credit	10%	Recent applications and recently opened accounts.
Credit mix	10%	Experience with different kinds of credit.

Source: [myFICO score factors](#). These percentages describe broad categories, not a formula for predicting your next score.

You do not need to borrow money simply to add a type of account. Affordability comes first.

FIELD GUIDE

Payment history needs attention

Review each account for past-due amounts and reported late-payment months. Compare them with statements, receipts, and any written hardship or deferment agreement.

If the payment information is wrong

Identify the specific month and error. Ask the reporting company and the company that supplied the data to investigate, using the records that support your position.

If the information is accurate

Focus on making upcoming payments on time. If you may miss a payment, contact the creditor early about available options. Do not claim an accurate payment history is fraudulent or incorrect.

- List every due date.
- Set reminders and monitor any automatic payments.
- Choose extra payments only after covering essential expenses and required minimums.

A dispute does not pause your current payment obligations. Follow any separate written agreement with the creditor.

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High balances may be weighing you down

Credit utilization compares a reported card balance with its credit limit. Review both individual cards and the combined totals.

Reported balance	Credit limit	Utilization
\$900	\$1,000	90%
\$300	\$1,000	30%
\$90	\$1,000	9%

Calculation: balance divided by limit, multiplied by 100. These examples show the math, not predicted score changes.

A manageable plan

- Record each balance, limit, statement date, and payment due date.
- Keep spending within the repayment plan.
- Pay down balances as your budget allows; lower reported utilization generally helps.
- Do not pay interest merely to carry a balance for scoring purposes.

30% is not a guaranteed safe threshold. Score effects depend on your overall file and the model used.

FIELD GUIDE

Applications and account age matter

Frequent card applications can add inquiries and new accounts without solving an existing problem. Before applying again, decide what the new account accomplishes and whether you can afford it.

Review before you add or close an account

- Read the reasons for a recent denial.
- Check whether an eligibility tool uses a soft inquiry and when a hard inquiry occurs.
- Compare fees and benefits on existing accounts.
- Consider the effect of closing a card on available credit and utilization.

Do not apply for several credit cards assuming they will be treated as a single rate-shopping inquiry. Different credit products and scoring models have different rules.

New account I am considering and why

What I will resolve before applying

FIELD GUIDE

Separate report errors from real debt

What you find	Useful next action
A balance that conflicts with a paid or settled account record	Gather the completion or payment evidence and dispute the specific balance.
An account you do not recognize	Investigate the reporting name. If it is not yours, follow the error or identity theft process.
Accurate negative payment history	Build a repayment and on-time payment plan; do not submit a false dispute.
A debt collector contact	Review the validation notice and applicable response deadline.
A result you do not understand	Compare the response with your original claim and documents.

Accurate negative information is not automatically removable because it lowers your score. A paid debt can still have a reportable history.

ACTION PLAN

Your next 30 days

When	Action
This week	Get your reports, list due dates, and identify your highest-priority factual issue.
Next week	Gather supporting records and send a clear dispute if an error exists. Build your payment plan.
Weeks 3 and 4	Track delivery and responses. Keep current payments on schedule and avoid unnecessary applications.
End of the month	Review what changed and what remains. Use actual receipt dates for dispute timing.

One payment habit I will improve

One report item I will investigate

My realistic extra payment amount

My next review date

RESOURCES

Sources and next steps

Reference links checked September 14, 2026. Use the official resources below for current instructions and details.

myFICO | How FICO Scores are calculated

[Open resource](#)

CFPB | Disputing a credit report error

[Open resource](#)

FTC | Disputing errors on your credit reports

[Open resource](#)

CFPB | When a card issuer can review your report

[Open resource](#)

Put your next move on the calendar

Visit **itsownlymoney.com** to explore Ownly ONCE financial readiness coaching and complete the assessment. Bring your goals and a list of questions; keep sensitive report documents in a secure channel.

Explore Ownly ONCE and start your assessment

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